

Chapter 106-3

Liang Shi struggled to piece this memory back together in her mind, then recalled that very quiet and reserved Chen Mian.

Chen Mian, who had now become a famous painter.

She was still as "strange" as ever.

But Liang Shi didn't dwell on it for long and brought the topic back to Liang Xinran: "Liang Xinran put Chen Mian's sketchbook through the wash?"

"Yes." Liang Wanwan became sad as she talked about this. "I was just changing clothes for a moment, and she threw my jacket into the washing machine. Even though those papers were laminated, they still got completely soaked."

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When you thought about it, Liang Wanwan was just unlucky.

Qiu Zimin had called her saying she was sick, and that Dage and Erge were both going to leave home.

Liang Wanwan was worried. After finishing her sketching trip during the day, she returned to the villa that evening.

She habitually carried Chen Mian's sketchbook with her. She usually kept it in her bag, but she hadn't brought her bag today, so she put it in her jacket pocket. She liked to flip through it when she had nothing to do.

Although this sketchbook was something Liang Shi had helped her obtain, Liang Shi didn't know that Liang Wanwan had actually been secretly in love with Chen Mian for many years.

From the time Liang Wanwan went to the art studio to find Liang Shi and bring the brushes she had left at home, she had seen the girl sitting by the window painting.

The girl's skin was an almost sickly pale. Her pupils were very small. She sat before the easel with great concentration. Sunlight fell on her nearly sickly white skin—there was clearly nothing remarkable about it, but in Liang Wanwan's eyes, it made her lose herself.

At that time, Liang Wanwan simply thought she was beautiful and felt a hazy kind of fondness.

She just wanted to get to know that jiejie.

She didn't know what kind of feelings those were, or perhaps those feelings hadn't yet sprouted.

Afterward, she frequently used the same excuse to go to Liang Shi's art studio, frequently seeing Chen Mian.

But Chen Mian never noticed her.

Chen Mian was always painting one particular painting—the back view of a girl wearing a white dress.

Chen Mian was always melancholic, sentimental, yet captivating.

As she grew older, Liang Wanwan finally understood her own feelings. She hid this affection away and didn't dare approach Chen Mian.

Chen Mian was a lonely moon that could only be gazed upon from afar.

Wanting Chen Mian's autograph was also because she wanted to put an end to her absurd secret crush.

She couldn't be the most special person by Chen Mian's side, nor could she be Chen Mian's sweetheart, so she just wanted a special autograph.

That way, she wouldn't have wasted her youth.

So she had gone to Liang Shi.

Liang Wanwan didn't get Chen Mian's autograph, but she got a sketchbook more precious than any autograph. Yet she couldn't feel happy.

For her, an autograph could have put an end to that secret crush.

But the sketchbook had ignited hope within her. She would always pay attention to Chen Mian on various platforms, following her works and activities.

She only had one person in her Weibo special follows—Chen Mian.

That sketchbook was her only hope, containing all the emotions of her adolescence and even now.

Liang Wanwan valued this sketchbook so much that even Ling Dang knew it must never be touched.

So Liang Wanwan hadn't been careful. After returning home, she casually threw her jacket on the sofa and went to see Qiu Zimin.

Qiu Zimin had just returned from the hospital not long ago. She sat on the bed looking sickly, her complexion pale, and she seemed to have aged considerably.

Liang Wanwan sat by the bed comforting her, hearing the same old things—that Liang Shi was too good at manipulating people, that both her brothers were siding with her, that they were causing chaos in the family right now, and that she really shouldn't have picked up Liang Shi in the first place.

The advice to Liang Wanwan was also the same as before: stay away from Liang Shi, don't hang around with that kind of person.

Liang Wanwan was inarticulate, not good at speaking, and had a dull personality. She was used to being invisible at home.

She wasn't as flamboyant as Liang Shi, who received all of Qiu Zimin's favor and could do whatever she wanted.

The things Qiu Zimin said to her most often were: don't compare yourself to your jie, don't learn from her, stay away from her.

Liang Wanwan didn't dare defy Qiu Zimin or go against her wishes, so she usually tried not to talk to Liang Shi. Especially since she didn't often talk to anyone in this family anyway—she was often forgotten even when sharing the same space with everyone.

She had gotten used to it.

But anyone would feel uncomfortable hearing Qiu Zimin say such things, so after starting university, Liang Wanwan didn't come home often.

She would rather be invisible at school than be invisible at home.

Liang Wanwan did know that her brothers and sister were all quite nice.

Her two brothers were much older than her. Although they looked after her too, it wasn't as much as Liang Shi did.

Her middle school wasn't far from Liang Shi's school. Back then, Liang Shi had already started being a troublemaker.

But as her younger sister, Liang Wanwan wasn't as formidable as her. Instead, she was often isolated at school.

Liang Shi had once told her: "Maybe it's you who's isolating the entire world."

Liang Wanwan was what people commonly called someone with strong "dull perception"¹, so Qiu Zimin's words went in one ear and out the other. She just reminded her to rest well.

Because she still had early classes tomorrow, Liang Wanwan went back to her room to pack up and was about to leave. When she went downstairs to put on her jacket, she found she couldn't find it.

She was scared to death. She called several servants, but none of them knew. Then she saw Liang Xinran smiling and asking her: "Are you looking for the one you wore when you came back? I saw it had mud splatters on it, so I took it to wash. I put a new one on the sofa for you."

Liang Wanwan nearly broke down on the spot. She rushed to the washing machine, almost reaching in with her bare hands to grab the clothes.

Liang Xinran pressed pause on the washing machine and asked cautiously: "What's wrong?"

Liang Wanwan couldn't be bothered to respond to her. She pulled her jacket out of the washing machine, only to find that all the sticky notes had been soaked. They had been kept for several years—how could they possibly be of good enough quality to withstand this?

Not being completely ruined was already the best outcome.

But that was Chen Mian's sketchbook.

Liang Wanwan placed it by her pillow every night—it was something she had poured all her hopes into, day and night.

Now it was gone, just like that.

Liang Wanwan looked at her and shouted: "Why did you touch my things?"

The usually silent, wooden, and taciturn Fourth Miss suddenly erupted, startling even the servants.

Liang Xinran stood in front of her, opening and closing her mouth hesitantly, then said: "I... saw your clothes were dirty, so I wanted to help you. It just so happened that last time when I went shopping with... with Mom, I saw some clothes that would suit you. I wanted to see you in pretty clothes."

"Then why didn't you check the pockets before washing?" Liang Wanwan demanded.

Liang Xinran stammered: "I... I forgot."

Her expression was innocent, which only made people more irritated.

Liang Wanwan looked at the sketchbook in her hands, all kinds of emotions piling up in her heart. She gritted her teeth, thinking of Qiu Zimin still lying sick in bed, and was about to swallow her anger.

But then Liang Xinran said: "Is this... thing very important? I'm sorry, Wanwan. Let me get you a new one."

The moment those words fell, Liang Wanwan couldn't help but slap her.

The crisp sound of the slap echoed through the house, stunning all the servants.

This... was this still the same wooden Fourth Miss?

Liang Wanwan said angrily: "You can't afford to replace it!"

After saying that, she ran off.

Footnotes:

¹ "Dull perception" (鈍感力): A Japanese concept (donkanryoku) that refers to the ability to let things roll off one's back, not being overly sensitive to criticism or negative situations. In this context, it means Liang Wanwan doesn't take things to heart easily.